Because I Wanted to Say

By Sean O'Donnell

ANN: We were dancing at my wedding *(pantomime dancing outrageously)* and he said:

STEVEN: *(Off-stage)* "We'll always have Poughkeepsie."

ANN: *(She peruses a photo album and stops at a particular photo.)*The photographer caught us laughing in a cloud of white wedding dress and Grey Flannel, I told my husband, that picture, for me, totally summed up my relationship with Steven.

STEVEN: *(Entering stage left. Stands behind ANN's chair)* I loved it, because it showed you laughing – really laughing. Not that other thing you do when you're being flirtatious or insecure.

ANN: When I'm playing my "Home movies in my mind," it's that image of Steven that always draws me in. There are other more colorful clips, but that's the one I love. Steven, so handsome in blue linen and a red polka dot tie. Dancing me from one part of my life to another, as he'd done so many times before. *(She slowly opens the urn.)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *We hear people talking about "closure" as if there is a door that can be shut after experiencing the death of a loved one*
ACTRESS: *But really . . . . Why would anyone seek closure? Why would anyone want to close the door on thoughts of that special person?*
ACTOR: *It's true that grief will soften in the years after a loss, but the door to memories should always be open*
ACTRESS: *And the opportunity to say the things that need to be said*
ACTOR: *Should never be locked in a casket, or an urn.*
TOGETHER: *Because I Wanted to Say by Sean O'Donnell*

STEVEN: *(Crosses center, and holds his hand out to ANN)* I always said "When you know where you're going . . . "

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ANN: *(Seeing STEVEN, she rises and takes his hand. He twirls her into a dance pose with ANN facing the audience)* "You know what to wear." *(She laughs)* It was strange how it hit me. The things I missed first about Steven were not what I would have thought.

STEVEN: For instance?

ANN: For instance, that funny laugh we used to do. Our secret calling card. *(She demonstrates. STEVEN joins in)* Without Steven providing the harmony, it was . . . I don't know . . . *(They break the pose)*

STEVEN: One hand clapping. And . . .

ANN: The million funny things he said to make me laugh. And I can't recall one of them right now. His strange way of looking at things. These things are already fading, and that's what scares me. Scare me more . . .

STEVEN: Than all the scary stuff that came before.

ANN: Because if I can't remember, what is left is an old Godiva box filled with some letters. No stories, no secrets, nothing to tell.

STEVEN: I wanted to tell you. I started to tell you so many times. But . . .

ANN: I think I finally knew before he told me. The shock, the rage I felt was incredible. I wanted to kill him. And I wanted to kill however did this to him.

STEVEN: *(Dryly. Out)* It was too late for that.

ANN: It was no longer about causes and contributions Ribbons and ranting. The enemy had made a successful attack into my life.

STEVEN: Of course, I wasn't the first.

ANN: Not the first, but to me, the most important.

STEVEN: Telling you was one of the most terrifying and important moments of my life.

ANN: Steven, how could you let this happen? How could you do something so stupid?

STEVEN: *(Out)* It was the wrong thing to say.

ANN: Of course, that's not what I meant. But when faced with that particular piece of news, your first reaction is not likely to be "How inconvenient."

STEVEN: The funny part is, and I don't mean to trivialize, but it was inconvenient.

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ANN: I'll never forget his face when he told me. One part "Dark Victory," two parts Blance DuBois *(She smiles)* I wanted to smack him.

STEVEN: Perhaps I was a trifle melodramatic. I mean it was a difficult moment. And a difficult moment is always easier when you're Bette Davis.

ANN: I never thought I couldn't go on without him. But I couldn't imagine certain parts of my life without Steven. It hurt my heart to think Steven wouldn't be there to help my daughter grow. That she'd be denied his humor, his whimsicality, his love.

STEVEN: I'm telling you I was afraid that we would try to stuff every moment after full of caring and sharing. Try to make every meeting so special, so precious, we'd never forget it.

ANN: We started to have strange conversations. What about her prom dress?

STEVEN: For God's sake, she's two years old.

ANN: I know, but . . .

STEVEN: Tell her to remember the shoes have to match the bag.

ANN: Catholic school?

STEVEN: *(Stares at her for a beat)* Don't be ridiculous.

ANN: Boys?

STEVEN: *(Interested)* Boys? *(He takes her hand.)*

ANN: You know, the good from the bad. The naughty from the nice.

STEVEN: Usually, the naughty are the nice.

ANN: Steven!

STEVEN: Just make sure none of them have "Judy: The Decca Years" in their lunch box. You'll be fine.

ANN: That's not what I meant.

STEVEN: I know what you meant. You'll be fine.

ANN: I don't want to be fine.

STEVEN: You'll be . . .

ANN: Without you. Without your . . .

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STEVEN: *(Sings two lines from an up tempo old standard)* You'll be fine. *(perhaps Harpy Parson's "You'll Be Fine": see* https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jMuycuDgeDQ *for song) (They sit for a moment)* Do you remember how you always used to plan your funeral?

ANN: Steven! *(Gets up and crosses to the chair stage left)*

STEVEN: Tell me about it again.

ANN: Don't be macabre.

STEVEN: Come on now. . . there were five little blond girls.

ANN: Brunette . . . and there were six . . . all in white. . . dresses, shoes, they carried nosegays of violets with long, trailing, pink ribbons.

STEVEN: And the coffin?

ANN: Glass. Made entirely of glass.

STEVEN: I loved that part. It's sooo Snow White.

ANN: And they played Italian opera throughout the service. And at the end, my mother heaves herself onto my casket and says "Take me too, God, take me too!"

STEVEN: No wonder I love you. You're such a drama queen.

ANN: *(Beat)* I have something to tell you.

STEVEN: Another shocking confession?

ANN: I was thinking about us, you and me.

STEVEN: Uh huh?

ANN: And I realized even though I married someone else, it's like all these years I've had a secret, second marriage to you.

STEVEN: *(Beat)* Does your husband know about this?

ANN: No.

STEVEN: Good. Go on.

ANN: It's just that even though we never . . . I don't think we could be closer.

STEVEN: *(Dramatically posing)* "And should I die this instant, I had lived Her time to a minute."

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ANN: The Duchess of Malfi, Act 4 *(STEVEN drops dramatic pose)* You see, a light . . . a light turned off in the middle and you can't help but wonder where was it going, what was ahead? All those choices that never had a chance.

STEVEN: Sort of like a mini-series with no end.

ANN: An unfinished melody, a broken blossom, a . . .

STEVEN: Honey, get ahold of yourself.

ANN: Some things were said; and some were left unsaid. But no matter how you try and prepare yourself, you're never fully prepared.

STEVEN: Maybe not saying it was our way of saying it. Or perhaps, we felt in some greater cosmic scheme of things we just didn't have to.

ANN: I supposed we thought we'd be ready to say it when . . .

STEVEN: Or if we never said it, the moment would never come.

ANN: Good-bye.

STEVEN: Good-bye.

ANN: Unfinished business, no, I don't think that's it. I think I tried to conjure Steven because I wanted to say . . .

STEVEN: Thank you. . . because I wanted to say . .

ANN: *(Breaking down)* I'm not fine without you!

STEVEN: Because I wanted to say. **. .**

ANN: There were moments . . .

STEVEN: There were moments . . .

ANN: When I felt like we were two halves

TOGETHER: of the same person . . .

ANN: Because I wanted to say . . .

STEVEN: There wasn't a secret I never tell you . . .

ANN: There wasn't anything I wouldn't have done . . .

STEVEN: Well

ANN: Well . . . . I still talk to you when I'm lonely

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STEVEN: Because I wanted to say . . .

ANN: Even when I think I'm forgetting.

STEVEN: I remember it all.

ANN: Because I wanted to say . . . .

TOGETHER: I miss you.

(The words hang between them. STEVEN stands behind her for a long moment. He leans over and presses his cheek to hers. ANN closes her yes. STEVEN slowly exits.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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